



1774

LOUIS XVI BECOMES KING OF FRANCE

At the age of just 19, Louis succeeded his grandfather, Louis XV, to become the last king of France before the French Revolution (1789). He inherited a kingdom deeply in debt, in which resentment of the monarchy was growing. A weak, indecisive man, Louis proved unable to combat the forces working to thwart much-needed economic and social reforms. His decision to convoke the States-General (a gathering of the Church, nobility, and commons) set the Revolution in motion.

◁ Bust of Louis XVI

1774 The Ottoman Empire cedes Crimea to Russia at the end of the Russo-Turkish War

1774

1772 The Qianlong Emperor orders the creation of the *Siku Quanshu*, the largest series of books in Chinese history

1773 James Cook circumnavigates Antarctica on his second voyage to the Southern Hemisphere



△ Depiction of the Boston Tea Party, engraving

1773

BOSTON TEA PARTY

A key grievance of American colonists against the British was that they had to pay taxes, yet had no representation in the British parliament. In protest, a group of Massachusetts colonists tipped a cargo of tea from British ships into Boston harbour on 16 December. British retaliation prompted the colonists to call the First Continental Congress (1774) to discuss America's future.



1738-1820
GEORGE III

King of Great Britain and Ireland (1760-1820), George III's hard line against dissent in the colonies after the Boston Tea Party precipitated their loss in the Revolutionary War.